

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-12-28

To the bahá'ís of the world

beloved friends,

in the course of the four year plan, we have been reviewing those laws of the kitáb-i-Aqdas which are not yet universally applied, in order to determine which of them it would be timely to implement now.

in every land we see a growing thirst for spiritual life and moral clarity.

There is recognition of the ineffectiveness of plans and programs for human

betterment which are not rooted in lives of spiritual awareness and ethical virtue. who should be better equipped to satisfy this longing than those

who are already inspired by the Teachings of bahá'u'lláh and aided by his power?

we have determined, therefore, that it is imperative for all the believers to deepen their awareness of the blessings conferred by the laws which directly foster the devotional life of the individual and, thus, of the community. 314.1

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698The essentials of these laws are known to all bahá'ís, but acquiring greater insight into their significance must include carrying out all the divinely revealed aspects of their observance. These are the laws which pertain to obligatory prayer, fasting and recitation of the greatest Name ninety-five times a day.

bahá'u'lláh asserts: "one who performeth neither good deeds nor acts

of worship is like unto a tree which beareth no fruit, and an action which leaveth no trace. whosoever experienceth the holy ecstasy of worship will

refuse to barter such an act or any praise of god for all that existeth in the world. fasting and obligatory prayer are as two wings to man's life. blessed be the one who soareth with their aid in the heaven of the love of god, the

lord of all worlds.”

The friends have long been familiar with the great importance which bahá’u’lláh attaches to daily obligatory prayer and to the observance of the fast, but a number of aspects of the law, such as those concerning ablutions, traveling and the compensation for prayers missed, remained to be made universally applicable. This step is now taken. Thus all elements of the laws

dealing with obligatory prayer and fasting are, without any exception, now applicable.

we have also decided that it is timely for bahá’ís in every land to take to their hearts the words of the kitáb-i-Aqdas: “it hath been ordained that every believer in god, the lord of judgment, shall, each day, having washed his hands and then his face, seat himself and, turning unto god, repeat ‘Alláh-u-Abhá’ ninety-five times. Such was the decree of the maker of the heavens when, with majesty and power, he established himself upon the thrones of his Names.”

315-1 let all experience the spiritual enrichment

brought to their souls by this simple act of worshipful meditation.

The spiritual growth generated by individual devotions is reinforced by loving association among the friends in every locality, by worship as a community and by service to the faith and to one’s fellow human be-

ings. These communal aspects of the godly life relate to the law of the mashriqu’l-A dhkár which appears in the kitáb-i-Aqdas. Although the time has not come for the building of local mashriqu’l-A dhkárs, the holding of regular meetings for worship open to all and the involvement of bahá’í communities in projects of humanitarian service are expressions of this element of bahá’í life and a further step in the implementation of the law of god.

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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

699bahá’u’lláh has written: “ we have adorned the heaven of utterance with the stars of divine wisdom and holy ordinances as a bounty on our part. verily, we are the ever-forgiving, the most generous. o friends of god

throughout the regions! know ye the value of these days and cling unto whatsoever hath been sent down from god, the most great, the most exalted. verily, he remembereth you in the most great prison, and instructeth you in that which will cause you to draw nigh unto a station that delighteth the eyes of the pure in heart. glory rest upon you and upon those who have attained unto that living fountain which floweth forth from my wondrous pen."

it is our prayer at the Sacred Threshold that the greater attention to the spiritual heart of the Teachings which these laws express will enhance the devotion of the friends to the Source of all bounties and attract to the cause the receptive souls among his spiritually famished children.

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Passing of Amatu'l-Bahá Rúhíyyih Khánúm

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]